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1 Feature Interview: Gyeonggi Superintendent of Education

"Life Isn't Just About Getting into a Good University" : A Conversation on School and Life with An Minseok Gyeonggi Superintendent of Education

On Thursday, October 8, 2026, students from PRISMTIMES, Gwangtan High School's English language newspaper club, interviewed An Minseok, Gyeonggi Superintendent of Education, at the library of Byeolharam Elementary School in Paju. The students arranged the meeting after applying to the Gyeonggi Provincial Office of Education's "The Superintendent Comes to You" (교육감이 간다) initiative. The program lets schools invite the superintendent to hear and discuss their experiences and concerns. The students asked about Ahn's school days and views on education, educational opportunities at rural schools in northern Gyeonggi Province, and his advice for students considering their future careers. He emphasized the importance of sports and artistic activities that students can enjoy throughout their lives and expressed his hope that they would pursue what they want to do and lead happy lives. The following Q&A is an edited account of their conversation.

Q1. Looking back on your school days, is there a teacher or moment you still remember? Have those experiences influenced your views on education today?

No particular teacher comes to mind. My teachers mostly told me to study hard. I don't recall anyone who helped me think about my future career or offered helpful life advice. In that respect, I do not think schools today are very different from when I was a student. I believe schools are losing sight of what they should be. They have come to operate like private exam preparation academies, and getting into a good university has become students' main goal. High school should be a happy, enjoyable time, yet many students go through a difficult period. I see this as a problem created by our education system and society, not by individual students, and I want to change it. Getting into a good university should not be the ultimate goal of life, and attending one does not necessarily make you happy. Even if changing the university admissions system is difficult right now, I believe schools should give students the chance to learn a sport and a musical instrument they can enjoy throughout their lives. That is why I emphasize RAS education. High school students are not machines built only to study. The more pressure they feel about university admissions, the more they need time to play sports, take part in artistic activities they enjoy, and catch their breath. For this reason, I believe RAS education, which can bring energy and enjoyment to school life, is especially important for high school students. Sports and the arts can improve students' physical and emotional well-being, which may also help them concentrate on their studies. Studying should not be all they do. I hope students will get along well with their friends, show consideration for others, and develop their thinking skills through reading.

A Closer Look at RAS Education

RAS stands for Reading, Arts, and Sports. The Gyeonggi Provincial Office of Education promotes this initiative in reading, arts, and sports education. The program connects these activities with the school curriculum and everyday school life to help students develop their thinking skills, emotional awareness, and physical health in a balanced way. Activities include book discussions, performances, exhibitions, and school sports clubs. The program also emphasizes students' active involvement in choosing and planning their own activities.

Q2. Gwangtan High School is located in a rural area of northern Gyeonggi Province, where students have fewer resources and opportunities for career exploration, cultural experiences, and educational activities than those at schools in large cities. You have emphasized balanced education across Gyeonggi. Which current policies aimed at reducing these regional gaps will directly benefit students at small rural schools in the north, and how do you plan to expand them?

I want to mention two approaches. First, we need a deputy superintendent dedicated to education in northern Gyeonggi to reduce the educational gap between the province's southern and northern parts. The superintendent should give this deputy the authority and responsibility to effectively serve as the superintendent for the northern region. The second approach is to connect small schools. If several schools share classes, facilities, and programs, they can reduce the disadvantages of their small size. I believe a group of three or four schools operating together as one school could be a good solution. Of course, this wouldn't solve every underlying problem, but sharing resources could gradually improve educational opportunities.

Q3. You studied physical education before serving in the National Assembly and becoming superintendent of education. Having taken on new challenges at several points in your career, what advice would you give to students who are still unsure about their career path or struggling to choose one?

I do not consider myself especially gifted compared with others. However, I do believe I have a strong desire to take on challenges. I served five terms in the National Assembly, and I have continued to take on new challenges since becoming superintendent. Phone-free school policies, RAS education, and plans for a bureau to protect teachers' rights are all examples of those efforts. Taking on challenges requires the courage to try without fearing failure. I hope students keep trying and don't give up when things get difficult. Whatever you do, I also hope you will choose what you want to do rather than simply following what your parents tell you to do. Your parents' expectations may be different from your own wishes. I believe that choosing what you want to do and giving it your best can lead to a happy life. To me, a happy life matters more than a successful one. Whatever career you choose, I hope you truly want to do it.

다각도로 세상을 분석하는

PRISMTIMES

'프리즘 타임즈'는 프리즘이 빛을 여러 색으로 나누듯, 세상을 다각도로 분석하고 다양한 관점을 영어로 전달하는 영자신문 동아리입니다. 한 가지 시선에 머물지 않고, 학교와 지역 사회의 이슈를 학생의 시각으로 바라보며 다양한 색깔의 이야기를 담아내고 있습니다. 저희는 직접 시민들을 만나 인터뷰하고, 학교의 주요 행사나 지역사회를 취재하며, 기사 작성과 편집과정을 통해 저널리즘의 기본을 배우고 있습니다.

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International Exchange with Agra International School on Smart Cities

In the first half of this year, students from Gwangtan High School participated in an international exchange program with The International School Agra (TISA) in India, themed "Smart Cities." Students met online to introduce the smart technologies used in their cities. They also conducted peer interviews to explore how technology is transforming urban areas in both countries. In this article, we introduce the smart technologies of Paju and Agra presented during the exchange, along with the stories and experiences we shared throughout the program. To begin, we would like to introduce The International School Agra. The International School Agra (TISA) has a large campus, accommodating more than 1,150 students, over 110 dedicated faculty and staff members, and more than 34 buses. For more than 11 years, TISA has worked to build a bright, hopeful future for its students. TISA offers a variety of extracurricular activities, seminars, and competitions that help students grow beyond the regular curriculum. Its wide range of sports facilities supports students' physical health while also helping them develop teamwork. TISA aims to nurture students with the knowledge, skills, and character needed to become confident, resilient individuals prepared to succeed in a rapidly changing society. Now, let's take a look at some of the activities offered by The International School Agra. Believing that true education should extend beyond the classroom and reach the wider world, TISA offers a variety of educational activities that make its learning experience unique. First is the Alumni Community. Students can gain internship experience and receive career guidance from alums. The school also encourages active alumni participation through a dedicated platform.

s can also participate in sports activities in the morning and evening. The school offers a variety of sports, including cricket, basketball, volleyball, badminton, and ndo. TISA also provides various academic support programs. In the Indian education system, students take a national or central-level examination called the Board the end of their secondary or senior secondary education. TISA offers special classes to help students prepare for these exams. In addition, supplementary classes ning programs for competitions, entrance exams, and qualification exams help students build strong, well-balanced academic skills. The school also offers summer Through activities such as music, movie appreciation, cooking, art, English communication, and experiments, students can develop their intellectual curiosity and y. In addition, students can present and demonstrate their skills to an audience during Parent Invitation Days, competitions, local-level contests, special assemblies, formances. These activities help students build confidence and express their ideas in front of others. TISA also offers a variety of elective subjects and activities based BSE curriculum, a nationally recognized curriculum administered by the Central Board of Secondary Education in India. Because major national college entrance exams npetitions in India are based on the CBSE curriculum, these activities give students a practical foundation for successful university admission and strengthen their ic competitiveness. Finally, TISA has strong community and industry partnerships, which is one of the school's distinctive features. Located in Agra, the school has es to the local business community. Through these connections, TISA provides various opportunities, including regular lectures by experts and leaders from different ocational education and upskilling programs, and activities designed to develop students' entrepreneurial mindsets.

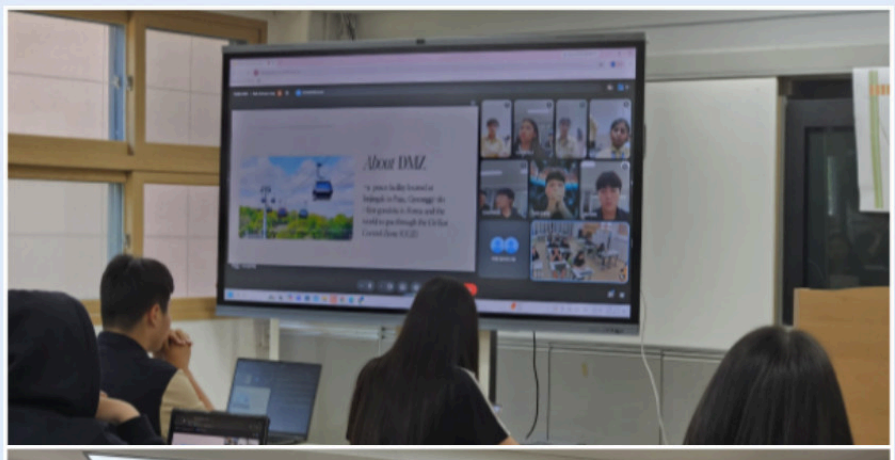
Interview with Agra International School

During this international exchange on smart cities, we not only introduced our cities and cultures to each other but also heard directly from students at Agra International School. We interviewed the students to learn more about their school life, culture, and thoughts on smart technologies.

Q1. What does a typical school day look like for you? What time do you usually start and finish?
A. A typical school day in Agra usually starts around 7:00 a.m. and finishes in the afternoon. After school, many students attend tuition classes, complete homework, and prepare for exams. We also spend time with family and friends. School life can be busy, but it teaches us discipline and responsibility.

Q2. Is exam competition really intense at your school? Do students feel a lot of pressure?
A. Examinations are important in India, so students work hard to achieve good results. Sometimes students feel pressure, especially before exams, but teachers and parents encourage us to stay positive and do our best.

Q3. How do students usually hang out or spend time together outside of class?
A. Outside school, students enjoy playing sports, visiting cafés, studying together, shopping, or spending time in parks. We also enjoy celebrating festivals and special occasions with our friends.



Q4. What's one thing about your school life that you think would really surprise Korean students?
A. One thing that may surprise Korean students is that many Indian students attend tuition classes after regular school hours. Another interesting aspect is the number of cultural celebrations and activities organized throughout the year.

Q5. Are there any unique school events or traditions at your school?
A. Yes. Schools in Agra celebrate Independence Day, Republic Day, Annual Day, Sports Day, and cultural festivals. These events help students learn teamwork, confidence, and respect for India's rich heritage.

Q6. If a Korean student came to your city, where would you take them?
A. We would love to take them to the Taj Mahal, Agra Fort, and Agra's local markets. We would also introduce them to Indian food and Agra's famous petha. These places beautifully represent our city's history, culture, and hospitality.

Q7. Can you tell me a little about the city or area you live in?
A. Agra is a historic city in northern India, best known for the Taj Mahal. It welcomes visitors from around the world and is known for its heritage, traditional crafts, delicious food, and warm hospitality.

From Learning to New Challenges : Inside Gwangtan High School's Second Career Research Festival

On June 12, 2026, Gwangtan High School held its second career research festival, "Scholé Archive." Building on last year's inaugural event, this year's festival grew in both scale and the depth of the research presented. A total of 47 teams introduced their semester-long research at booths. Nine teams were recognized for outstanding work and selected to present their research and findings on stage.

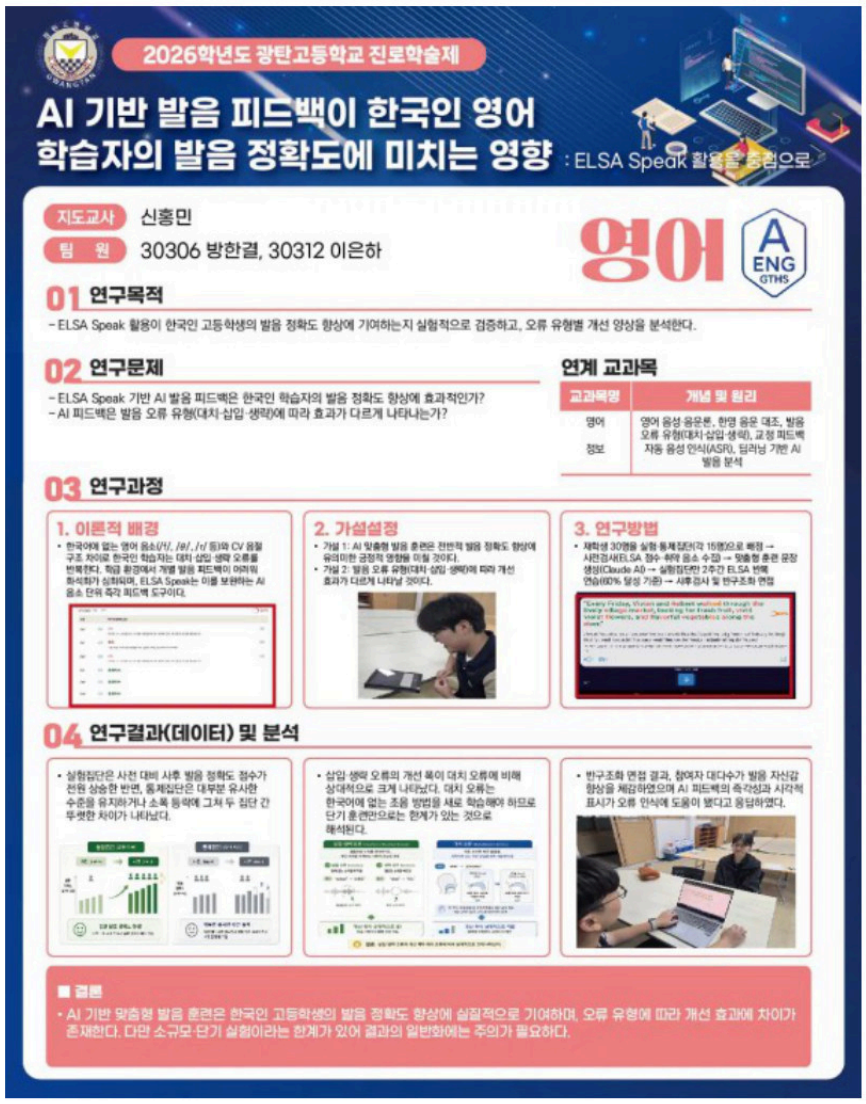
The stage presentations reflected students' diverse interests. Sihong Min, Yulchan Ha, and Doyoung Hwang presented "Simulating the Blast Resistance of Earthquake-Resistant, Base-Isolated, and Vibration-Controlled Structures Using Unity Physics." Hyowon Kim, Eunwoo Kim, and Hyeonseo Kim explored "Why do Different Onomatopoeic Words represent the Same Sound?" Hangyeol Bang and Eunha Lee investigated the effects of AI pronunciation feedback on Korean learners' English pronunciation accuracy using ELSA Speak. Other presentations included "Improving and Optimizing Seating Arrangements in the School Cafeteria" by Gunah Kim, Myeongwoo Seo, and Haesol Kim, and "Investigating Bone Mineralization and Demineralization Using Artificial Bone Models" by Junyul Park and Habin Song.

After judging, the Excellence Awards went to the teams of Gunah Kim, Myeongwoo Seo, and Haesol Kim, and Hyowon Kim, Eunwoo Kim, and Hyeonseo Kim. Junyul Park and Habin Song received the Top Excellence Award. Hangyeol Bang and Eunha Lee received the Grand Prize for their research on AI pronunciation feedback. We spoke with Eunha Lee about choosing their topic, conducting the experiment, preparing their presentation, and winning the award.

Q1. How did you form your team and choose your research topic? Did you have any disagreements along the way?
We were both interested in pursuing careers related to English, and we had already worked on several projects together, so forming a team felt natural. When choosing our topic, we wondered, "Can AI pronunciation feedback actually improve learners' pronunciation?" With so many people using AI learning apps these days, we wanted to see for ourselves how effective they were. We were also curious about how AI could be used in the classroom, which led us to choose this topic. Since we had worked together many times before, we understood each other well and carried out the research without major disagreements.

Q2. Were there any memorable moments during the research or presentation preparations?
One participant's reaction during the experiment really stayed with me. Although the student participated consistently, their pronunciation accuracy did not reach the level they had hoped for. They told us they wanted to quit, saying, "I can't do this."Preparing the presentation was challenging, too, especially cutting down our slides. We started with 53 slides, but with only ten minutes to present, we had to cut them to 29. Hangyeol and I stayed up all night in our dorm, putting our heads together to decide what to keep. It was really hard to remove slides we had worked so carefully on.

▲The Effects of ELSA Speak's AI Pronunciation Feedback on Korean Learners' English Pronunciation Accuracy by Hangyeol Bang and Eunha Lee



Q3. Many more teams participated this year than last year. How did it feel to win the Grand Prize?
With so many teams participating, I was honestly happy to reach the final round. Winning the Grand Prize made me happier than I could put into words. First, I'd like to thank Hangyeol, who stayed up with me to work through our ideas and prepare the presentation. I'm also grateful to our teacher, HongMin Shin, for supporting us when we felt exhausted or discouraged. Above all, we could not have completed the research without the friends who participated in our experiment. Through this experience, I discovered how enjoyable it is to test a question and find answers through an experiment. It strengthened my desire to continue researching and pursue a career related to English

Q4. What would you like to say to students participating in next year's festival?
Start with something you have always been curious about, rather than forcing yourself to choose a topic just because it sounds impressive. When you truly want to find the answer, it is easier to keep going through difficulties. Even if your results differ from what you expected, don't give up too quickly. Try to make the whole experience something you'll look back on fondly. Good results often follow when you enjoy the process. No matter how many teams are participating, believe you can do it, and keep challenging yourself. I'll be cheering you on at next year's festival!
This year's Scholé Archive allowed students to turn their questions into research and share both the process and the findings. The booths and stage presentations reflected a semester of careful thought and exploration. The Grand Prize team's story also offered a glimpse of the effort and collaboration involved in conducting an experiment and preparing a presentation. Their reflections on discovering the joy of research and gaining confidence in their career plans showed how meaningful the festival had been to them. We hope the knowledge and confidence students gained through this experience will encourage them to keep asking new questions and taking on new challenges.

야, 너도 생명화학할 수 있어.

Q. Could you briefly introduce yourself?
A. I'm Kim Juho, a chemistry teacher at Gwangtan High School. I'm also the teacher in charge of the school club, "야생화."

Q. What inspired you to major in chemistry?
A. I've been curious about many things since I was young, and chemistry best satisfied that curiosity. I also enjoyed explaining what I knew to people around me, so I naturally decided to major in chemistry.

Q. After majoring in chemistry, what made you decide to become a teacher?
A. I have always enjoyed explaining what I know to others, and I wanted to make science easier and more interesting for students. These interests played a major role in my decision to become a science teacher.

Q. What kinds of activities do you do in the club 'Yasaenghwa,' which you run?
A. I believe that there are limits to understanding science through theories and concepts learned only in class. So, in our club, we focus on experiments that let students see and experience what they learn in class. Through these hands-on experiments, students can develop a more concrete understanding of scientific concepts.

Q. Why did you name the club '야생화'?
A. The name '야생화' means "야, 너도 생명·화학 할 수 있어." It also reflects the club's focus on conducting experiments in life sciences and chemistry.

Q. What activities are you planning for next year's new members?
A. This year, since it was my first time running the club, I learned a lot and also identified areas I could have prepared better. If I run the club again next year, I plan to prepare and organize the activities more thoroughly based on this year's experience. The overall direction will be similar to this year, but I hope to make the club even better and more meaningful.

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Voices of Insight-3rd Grade

A Hidden Gem in Northeastern France : Discovering Metz

- Hangyeol Bang

A Hidden Gem in Northeastern France: Discovering Metz

The city of Metz, tucked away in northeastern France, calls to mind Paju, our own region back home. Its proximity to the capital, its location near an international border, its blend of urban and rural life, and its shared pattern of industrial and cultural development—Metz shares many striking similarities with Paju. Of course, the two cities carry different histories and face different circumstances today. Paju remains a border city shaped by Korea's ongoing division, while Metz, after a long history of territorial disputes, has become a symbol of peace and exchange in today's Europe. Examining both their similarities and differences offers a deeper understanding of Metz.

A City at the Heart of the Border Region

Metz is the central city of France's Grand Est region, situated close to the borders of Germany and Luxembourg. Its population is roughly 120,000 in the city proper and over 370,000 in the greater metropolitan area. From Paris, it's just 1 hour and 20 to 30 minutes away by high-speed rail (TGV), keeping it tightly connected to the capital—a feature that naturally brings Paju, so close to Seoul, to mind. The Moselle River, flowing through the heart of the city, gives Metz its scenic beauty while having long served as a vital route for people and goods. Along the riverbanks, the old town preserves its medieval architecture, which sits in harmony with more modern buildings, creating a cityscape where past and present coexist.

A History Spanning Thousands of Years

Metz's history stretches back roughly 3,000 years, to when Celtic peoples first settled the area. Under the Roman Empire, it grew into an important military and administrative hub, and in the centuries that followed, it changed hands repeatedly between France and Germany. After France's defeat in the Franco-Prussian War, the German Empire annexed Metz in 1871, but it returned to France after World War I in 1918. It was occupied once more by Nazi Germany in 1940 before being liberated by Allied forces in 1944. Having changed nationality three times in roughly half a century, Metz developed a history and culture shaped by its border location. Traces of this past remain visible throughout the city today. The Porte des Allemands, one of its most iconic landmarks, was once part of the medieval city walls and fortifications, underscoring Metz's historical role as a key defensive stronghold on the frontier. It's striking that a space once shaped by war and conflict is now a heritage site visited by locals and tourists alike.

▲ The Landscape of Metz

▲ View of Metz Cathedral

A City Where Industry, Culture, and Light Converge

Metz is both a historic and industrial city. It's home to a thriving automotive and tech sector, along with logistics and services, and its location near the border has made it a central hub in the economic corridor linking France, Germany, and Luxembourg. But what makes Metz truly special goes beyond economic growth. The city has long placed culture and the arts at the core of its development, with the Center PompidouMetz standing as its flagship example. Known for its striking, sculptural roof, this contemporary art museum partners with the Center Pompidou in Paris and hosts a rotating program of exhibitions and cultural events that have helped establish Metz as one of France's leading cultural cities.

Another must-see landmark is the Cathédrale SaintÉtienne de Metz. Nicknamed the "Cathedral of Light," it houses the largest surface area of stained glass in Europe, spanning roughly 6,500 square meters. For many visitors, watching sunlight pass through the glass and wash the interior in shifting color is one of Metz's most moving moments. Beyond the cathedral, the riverside promenade along the Moselle, the Temple Neuf, and the medieval Place Saint-Louis serve as everyday gathering spots where history blends naturally into daily life—not just for tourists, but for residents, too, who take strolls here and unwind, savoring the city's beauty together.

For an ideal afternoon, visit the cathedral late in the day to watch the stained glass shift colors as the light fades, then take an evening stroll around the illuminated Center PompidouMetz. Along the Moselle's riverside path, you can take in the evening sunlight filtering through narrow lanes and low buildings, and settling into a riverside café to watch cyclists and passersby drift by makes it easy to forget you're in a border city—the atmosphere is simply peaceful. In the evening, a riverside restaurant serving Lorraine's own quiche Lorraine, paired with a local wine, makes for a fine choice. Whether you're coming from Paris for a day trip or staying a night or two, Metz is more than enough—discover its many stories for yourself.

Why Are Korean Products Becoming Popular Worldwide?

- Juho Mun

In recent years, Korean products have become increasingly popular worldwide. From Korean food and cosmetics to fashion and entertainment, many people overseas are showing interest in Korean products. This phenomenon is often called the K-wave or Hallyu. As Korean culture spreads globally through media and the internet, Korean exports are also growing rapidly.

One major reason for this popularity is the influence of K-content such as K-pop, Korean dramas, and YouTube videos. Popular groups like BTS and BLACKPINK have attracted millions of international fans, while Korean dramas on Netflix have introduced Korean culture to people worldwide. As a result, many foreign consumers became interested in Korean products featured in dramas or used by celebrities. For example, Korean ramen, snacks, skincare products, and fashion items are now commonly sold in overseas stores.

Another reason is the quality and uniqueness of Korean products. Many Korean companies focus on trendy designs, advanced technology, and reasonable prices. Korean cosmetics, in particular, are famous for their innovative ingredients and skincare techniques. In addition, Korean food products have gained attention for their spicy, unique flavors. Social media platforms such as TikTok and Instagram also help Korean products spread quickly across countries.

The growing popularity of Korean products has positively affected Korea's economy and trade. Korea's exports of cosmetics, food, and cultural content continue to increase every year. This creates more opportunities for Korean companies to enter global markets and strengthens Korea's national brand image. Small businesses also benefit because online shopping lets them sell products internationally more easily than before.

However, there are also challenges. As global competition intensifies, Korean companies must keep improving quality and maintaining customer trust. Cultural trends can also change quickly, so businesses need to keep developing new ideas. To maintain the success of Korean products, innovation and global marketing strategies will remain important.

In conclusion, the worldwide popularity of Korean products is closely connected to the spread of Korean culture and the development of digital media. Through high quality, creative marketing, and global interest in K-content, Korean products are becoming an important part of international trade. The success of Korean products shows how culture can strongly influence the global economy and consumer markets.

Can Language Change Society? – Eunha Lee
: The Debate over Political Correctness in America

Language is more than a tool for communication. It reflects society's values, beliefs, and attitudes. In the United States, one of the biggest debates about language is Political Correctness (PC), which encourages people to use words that avoid discrimination based on gender, race, disability, or other identities. Over the past several decades, many English expressions have changed. For example, "chairman" is often replaced by "chairperson" or simply "chair". "Fireman" has become "firefighter", and "mankind" is increasingly replaced with "humankind". These changes aim to make language more inclusive and respectful. Supporters argue that language shapes how people think. They believe that replacing biased expressions with inclusive ones can reduce stereotypes and create a more equal society. For this reason, schools, universities, and many companies have adopted guidelines for inclusive language. However, critics claim that Political Correctness sometimes limits freedom of expression. They argue that people may become afraid to speak honestly because they worry about using the "wrong" words. Others believe that changing vocabulary alone cannot solve deeper social problems such as discrimination or inequality. Linguists point out that language constantly changes as society does. Political Correctness is not simply about replacing words; it reflects changing social values. Whether people support or oppose these changes, the debate shows that language can influence how people understand one another. As English continues to develop worldwide, the discussion of inclusive language reminds us that words are never just words: they carry history, culture, and social meaning.

In an Age When AI Provides Answers, Why Do Humans Need to Develop the Ability to Ask Questions? – Subin Son

We can get answers quickly without spending a long time searching for information. Recently, with the rapid development of generative AI, AI has evolved. AI now goes beyond simply searching for information. It can write text, suggest ideas, and even solve complex problems. These changes have made our lives much more convenient, but they also raise an important question: In an age when AI can answer most of our questions, do humans still need the ability to think and ask questions on their own?

As AI develops, I believe the human ability to ask questions becomes even more important. AI can generate answers, but humans still need to decide which problems matter, what questions to ask, and whether AI's answers are reasonable and reliable. Therefore, this report examines why humans need to develop the ability to ask questions in an age when AI can easily provide answers. It also explores why independently identifying problems, asking meaningful questions, and critically evaluating answers matter, and how these abilities connect to philosophical thinking and humanistic literacy. As generative AI continues to develop, the way people obtain information is changing significantly. In the past, people had to search through various sources and organize information themselves to find the answers they wanted. Today, however, we can get a large amount of information quickly simply by asking AI. Jensen Huang, CEO of NVIDIA, also explained in a television interview that advances in AI could help reduce the technology gap between people with professional technical skills and those without them. This shift suggests that while people may need less knowledge and fewer technical skills, it is becoming more important to understand what they need and decide how to use AI effectively. In an age when AI can generate answers, identifying problems and deciding what questions to ask becomes more important than simply knowing many answers.

Then, is simply asking AI many questions enough? In the age of AI, what matters is not the number of questions, but the ability to think independently and ask better ones. The study "A Study on Generative AI Question Prompt Generation and Usage Experiences According to College Students' Metacognitive Levels" found that students with higher metacognitive levels were more likely to ask questions that required critical thinking and evaluation rather than simple fact-checking. They also tended to ask additional questions based on AI-generated answers. Another study, "Development of a PBL-Based Questioning Activity Model Using Generative AI to Foster Critical Thinking," found that activities involving questioning, verifying, and reflecting on AI responses could help students develop critical thinking skills. These studies show that the ability to ask questions in the age of AI goes beyond simply writing effective prompts. It involves questioning AI-generated answers, checking their evidence, and developing one's own thinking.

Questioning is also closely connected to philosophical thinking. Philosophy does not simply accept existing answers as they are. Instead, it questions ideas that we often take for granted and examines the reasons and evidence behind them. Even if AI can quickly organize large amounts of information and generate answers, humans may become passive consumers of information if they allow AI to decide which problems matter, what questions to ask, and whether to accept its answers. Therefore, the humanistic literacy needed in the age of AI is not simply about having extensive knowledge of philosophy or classical works. Rather, it is the ability to question given information, consider different perspectives, and form one's own judgment. Ultimately, AI does not make human thinking unnecessary. Instead, it is shifting human thinking from "the ability to find answers" to "the ability to ask good questions and evaluate answers."

As AI continues to develop rapidly, the need for humans to search for information and find answers on their own is gradually decreasing. However, this research showed me that this change does not make human thinking unnecessary. Instead, as AI makes it easier to get a wide range of answers, it becomes even more important for humans to decide what questions to ask and to evaluate the evidence and validity of AI-generated answers critically.

Therefore, I believe that humanistic literacy in the age of AI is not simply about having a large amount of knowledge. It is about questioning what we usually take for granted, considering different perspectives, and forming our own judgments. In the future, we should use AI not only to get correct answers, but also to expand our thinking and generate new questions. Ultimately, in an age when AI provides more and more answers, what humans need is not to become people who know the most answers, but to become people who think independently and ask better questions.

How Much Should We Trust AI-Generated News? – Hanuel Lee

In recent years, advances in artificial intelligence (AI) have made it possible for anyone to create text, images, and videos quickly. These technologies let people produce information quickly and easily. However, they have also created a new problem: content that never happened can look real. In particular, fake images and videos created with AI can spread online as if they were real events, making the ability to distinguish fact from fiction more important than ever. In the past, people generally checked whether online information was reliable by comparing reports from different news organizations or checking the source. However, as generative AI has developed, it can now create content that closely resembles the appearance or voice of real people. As a result, simply looking at a piece of content is no longer enough to determine whether it is genuine. This issue is also important for teenagers. Students encounter a wide range of social and cultural issues through social media and online platforms. If they share information without checking its accuracy, false information can spread rapidly. Then, how should we approach information in the age of AI? One of the most important steps is to check the information's source. Rather than immediately accepting a post as true, we should check which news organization or institution published it and whether other reliable sources have reported the same event. At the same time, we should not view AI only negatively. AI can help us organize information, understand complex topics, and complete tasks that would otherwise take a great deal of time. Ultimately, the most important thing is not whether we use AI, but whether we can critically evaluate the information it produces. Through this project, I want to examine how AI is changing how we receive and use information, and how students respond to information they encounter online. To better understand this issue, we could conduct a survey asking questions such as "How often do you check the accuracy of information you see on social media?" and "Do you think you can distinguish AI-generated images from real images?" We could also interview teachers or experts in information and media. These activities would help us gather more specific, meaningful insights into how students perceive and respond to AI-generated information.

How Is the Sport We Love Made? – Daeeun Cho

We cheer for sports and look forward to watching our favorite athletes compete, but many different fields shape the world of sports. Sports management plays an important role in organizing games and managing teams, while sports marketing connects fans with teams, brands, and products. In recent years, AI and big data have been used to analyze athletes' performance and fans' consumer behavior. Sports science uses fields such as exercise physiology and biomechanics to study athletes' movements and physical changes scientifically. Creating a successful sporting event requires not only athletes but also professionals from many different fields. In particular, advances in data and technology are making sports easier to analyze and develop systematically. Sports events can also promote local tourism and businesses, influencing the local economy.

Therefore, sports have grown beyond simple competition and leisure activities and have become an important industry. As I have learned more about sports, I have become interested not only in game results but also in the management and science behind them. However, I believe that the most important part of developing sports is truly enjoying and being passionate about the sport we love. Genuine interest and passion help us understand games, athletes, and fans better. Rather than simply watching the sports we love, we should ask questions such as, "Why is this sport managed this way?" Through this process, we can discover new fields such as sports marketing, sports management, and sports science. For us, sports will no longer be just a hobby but a subject of exploration that brings together various academic fields. Moving forward, we should explore more deeply how data and technology affect sports based on our interest in the field. Above all, it is important to discover new possibilities in sports while truly enjoying and being passionate about it.

Exploring New Horizons-2nd Grade

Trapped in 'Shorts': Children's Cognitive Capacity Withering Away – Jaebeom Yeon

Today, short-form content—videos lasting less than a minute—has completely taken over adolescents' lives. However, this is far from a harmless pastime. Today's youth are suffering from the so-called "Popcorn Brain" phenomenon, a state in which the brain responds exclusively to immediate, intense stimuli while becoming numb to the slower pace of real life. Warning bells are ringing as the fleeting thrills of short-form videos erode children's literacy and systematically reshape their developing brains.

[What is a 'Popcorn Brain'?]

A psychological and neurological phenomenon where overexposure to the fast, intense visual stimuli of smartphones conditions the brain to react only to immediate, explosive sensations—much like popcorn popping over heat—rendering it indifferent to the slower, calmer stimuli of reality, such as reading or studying.

■ "Can't Read Beyond Three Lines": A Severe Literacy Deficit Overtakes Classrooms

Short-form content conditions students to quick visual stimuli, destroying their attention span for long texts and causing a severe "literacy drought." Statistics reinforce these observations of declining literacy and attention deficits among youth. As short-form viewing hours escalate, the capacity for deep, contextual thinking plummets. Instead of understanding text structurally, students merely "scan" pages as if skimming a video feed, leaving them oblivious to the nuanced meaning between the lines. Experts diagnose this as a classic cognitive side effect of the "Popcorn Brain."

■ "Give Back the Right to Be Bored": The Rise of Digital Detox Movements

Recognizing the gravity of the crisis, more schools and households are pioneering self-preservation measures. A prime example is the "Digital Detox" movement, which encourages deliberate distance from digital devices. More schools now require students to store their smartphones in lockers, encouraging them to play analog board games or spend 30 minutes a day sitting idly without any devices. At the same time, global media conglomerates face mounting criticism for trapping youth in predatory algorithmic loops solely to boost viewership metrics. Major developed nations across the United States and Europe have already introduced and are debating legislation aimed at restricting algorithmic recommendations and regulating feed exposure targeted at minors. While children indulge in "one-minute pleasures" dictated by algorithms, their capacity for independent thought is gradually eroding. It is high time to implement institutional checks against unchecked algorithmic monopolies while ensuring our children reclaim the invaluable "time to be bored" away from the screen.

The Increasing Use of Medical Imaging and the Problem of Unnecessary CT Scans – Yeju Lim

Medical imaging plays an important role in modern healthcare. X-rays and CT scans help doctors quickly identify diseases and injuries. However, the increasing use of medical imaging has also raised concerns about unnecessary examinations. CT scans use X-rays to create detailed images of the body's interior. Although they can help with diagnosis, unnecessary radiation exposure should be avoided. Why are unnecessary CT scans becoming a concern?

One reason is that medical imaging is often used to make a quick and accurate diagnosis. When symptoms are difficult to identify, doctors may use CT scans to check for serious diseases. In some cases, patients may also want more detailed tests because they feel additional examinations will lead to better treatment. However, not every patient needs a CT scan. If a test is not medically necessary, it may expose patients to radiation without providing enough benefit. The problem is also related to the increasing demand for medical services. As people become more interested in their health, the number of medical examinations can increase. In addition, medical technology continues to develop, making imaging tests easier to use in hospitals. This can help with early diagnosis, but it also means medical staff must decide carefully when a CT scan is truly needed.

Unnecessary examinations can also increase medical staff workload and costs. Hospitals need to manage limited equipment and staff efficiently. If too many patients receive unnecessary tests, those who need urgent examinations may have to wait longer. Therefore, the issue is not simply about radiation exposure. It is also connected to using medical resources efficiently. There are several possible solutions. Doctors should choose imaging tests based on the patient's symptoms and medical condition. Hospitals can also provide clearer information about the benefits and risks of CT scans. In addition, patients need to understand that more tests do not always mean better treatment. Use medical imaging when its benefits outweigh its risks.

CT scans are an important part of modern medicine, but they should not be used unnecessarily. Using medical imaging appropriately can protect patients from unnecessary radiation exposure and help hospitals use their resources more effectively. Finding the right balance between accurate diagnosis and patient safety remains a key challenge in modern healthcare.

Is Performance Assessment Fair? : The Reality Students Perceive

– Gwonneung Park

In recent years, the proportion of performance-based assessments in schools has steadily increased, reflecting a shift away from traditional exam-centered evaluation toward assessing a wider range of student competencies. This change can be seen as positive, as it aims to evaluate not only memorized knowledge but also problem-solving skills, collaboration, and expressive abilities. However, students still question the fairness of these classroom assessments. This leads to an important question: Are current performance assessments truly fair?

Many students feel that the evaluation criteria for performance assessments are unclear. Even when completing the same task, differences in grading standards among teachers or a lack of detailed evaluation guidelines can be confusing. In particular, when students are unclear about which aspects of the process matter most, they are more likely to feel dissatisfied than to accept the results. Such situations can reduce the credibility of assessments and negatively affect students' motivation to learn. Group projects are another major source of fairness issues.
In many cases, some students do most of the work while others contribute little but receive the same grade, creating what is often called the "freerider problem." This can make hardworking students feel that the system is unfair and lead to negative perceptions of collaborative learning. As a result, activities intended to develop teamwork skills may instead become sources of conflict.

To address these issues, educators should ensure clear, transparent evaluation criteria. Using rubrics to present detailed standards in advance helps students understand expectations and monitor their own performance. For group tasks, incorporating individual roles and contributions into the evaluation process can also enhance fairness.

Furthermore, continuous feedback during assessment allows students not only to receive grades but also to reflect on and improve their learning. Performance assessment should not be viewed merely as a tool for assigning scores, but as an educational method that supports students' growth. Therefore, fairness in assessment should include not only equal results but also transparency in the process and students' ability to understand and accept the outcomes. For students to truly benefit, assessment must be recognized as a process of understanding and growth rather than simple comparison and selection.

Ultimately, a fair performance assessment is not simply about applying the same criteria to everyone, but about appropriately reflecting each student's effort and learning process while guiding their future development. Moving forward, performance assessments should go beyond grading tools and instead serve as processes that help students learn independently and grow meaningfully.

Are Government and Schools Doing Enough to Protect Teenagers from Deepfake Crimes?

– Soocheol Kim

As artificial intelligence (AI) technology rapidly develops, our lives are becoming more convenient. However, technological advancement does not always bring positive changes. Recently, crimes using deepfake technology have emerged as serious social issues, and the number of teenage victims has been increasing. Deepfake crimes are not simply online jokes; they are serious digital crimes that threaten people's rights and safety.

Deepfake technology uses AI to create realistic fake faces, voices, or videos. Originally used in film and media, this technology has recently spread quickly through social media and online platforms and has been misused for criminal purposes. Teenagers are especially vulnerable because they frequently use social media and often upload their photos online. In fact, students' photos have been illegally used to create fake videos and spread them online, becoming a major social problem.

These deepfake crimes can cause serious emotional damage to victims. Victims may experience anxiety, shame, and stress, which can negatively affect their school life and relationships with others. In addition, once fake videos are uploaded online, they are very difficult to remove completely so that the damage can continue for a long time. This is why deepfake crimes should be viewed not only as personal problems but also as public issues that society must solve together. As digital technology continues to develop, crime methods are also becoming more advanced, making social awareness and action increasingly important.

Experts say the government and public institutions play an essential role in preventing deepfake crimes. The government should strengthen laws and penalties for digital crimes and improve the management of online platforms. Schools should also teach students about digital citizenship and how to protect personal information. Recently, the importance of digital crime prevention education for teenagers has grown, and administrative institutions and schools need to cooperate to create a safer digital environment.

In today's rapidly changing digital society, public administration is more important than ever. In the past, administration mainly focused on paperwork and civil services, but modern administration now protects citizens and addresses social problems through policies and systems. New digital crimes, such as deepfakes, show how important it is for governments to respond quickly and establish effective regulations. Therefore, in the future, administrative systems and policies that can both understand technological development and protect citizens will become even more necessary.

AI technology will continue to develop. What matters most is not the technology itself, but how people use it. To build a safer digital society, the government, schools, and citizens must all remain engaged and responsible. In addition, administrative efforts and proper policies are necessary to respond actively to changing social problems.

Crisis or Opportunity: The Impact That AI Can Have on Business Administration

– Yunjae Lee

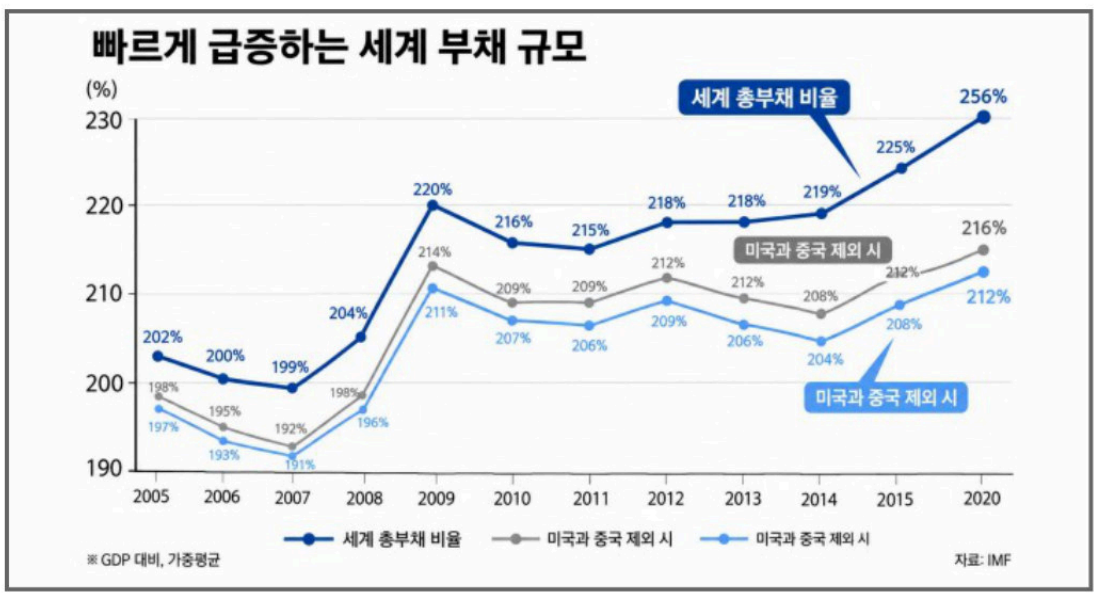
As artificial intelligence technology like ChatGPT advances rapidly, the future business world we will live in is also undergoing a massive transformation. Although many people worry that AI might eliminate human jobs, from a business administration perspective, it offers new opportunities and powerful tools. While past management relied on the intuition or experience of top executives, management today is shifting toward making the most rational decisions based on vast amounts of data analyzed by artificial intelligence. The personalized content recommendations we receive daily on YouTube or music apps also result from companies analyzing our preferences using AI management techniques. Now, artificial intelligence is permeating all areas of business management, not just marketing, including human resources, finance, and production. For example, when hiring new employees, companies use AI interviewers to evaluate applicants' capabilities objectively, and in factories, AI predicts product defect rates in advance to drastically reduce production costs. As technology maximizes management efficiency, interpreting and using AI-generated analytical results has become more important than ever for future business students. By leaving complex numerical calculations or repetitive routine tasks to technology, humans can now focus on crafting more valuable strategies.
Furthermore, artificial intelligence helps identify consumers' hidden needs and create new markets that did not exist before. In today's business landscape, where trend cycles accelerate rapidly, artificial intelligence synthesizes global trends and reactions in real time, showing companies the right direction to pursue. Amid these changes, business administration is reinventing itself not as a discipline that sells many products, but as an interdisciplinary field that uses cutting-edge technology to create social value. Therefore, sensitively capturing and exploring these technological trends starting in high school becomes essential to becoming a great business expert in the future.

However, no matter how smart artificial intelligence becomes, it can never replace the essence of business administration. That is the motivation that moves the hearts of organization members and ethical management that cares for marginalized groups. Artificial intelligence can present efficient figures, but it cannot exercise warm leadership that empathizes and communicates with team members to lead them toward a shared goal. Ultimately, the future of business administration will be led by people who combine cool technology with warm humanity. If one takes an interest in technological changes starting in high school while not neglecting the exploration of human nature, one can become a wonderful future business leader who uses technology as a tool to change the world for the better.

Global Debt Explodes, Is Korea Safe? – Seulchan Lee

The whole world is in the midst of a "war of debt"... The Largest increase since the COVID-19 pandemic

The world has been mired in unprecedented debt as investors rush to preempt artificial intelligence (AI) technology and governments increase defense spending amid rising geopolitical tensions. Not only big tech companies but also governments are scrambling to pour money into high-cost, high-tech industries, raising warnings of a global fiscal crisis. According to a report released by the International Financial Association (IIF), as of the end of last year, the world's total debt reached a new record high of $348 trillion (about 49 trillion won). This is a whopping $28.8 trillion (about 4 trillion won) from the previous year, the largest annual increase since the COVID-19 pandemic. The IIF cited high-tech investments, such as defense spending and the establishment of AI data centers, as the cause of this debt explosion. In fact, the United States has pledged to increase defense spending to about $1.5 trillion by 2027, and Europe is also expected to see its debt-to-GDP ratio rise by more than 18 percentage points by 2035. In addition, large-scale borrowing is becoming a global phenomenon as big tech companies and state-led investment in technology infrastructure combine.



What's the Situation in Korea? IMF: "Half of the World's Average, Good Financial Structure."

So what is the situation in Korea amid the global 'storm of debt'? Fortunately, Korea is building a safe barrier amid the global economic crisis. The International Monetary Fund (IMF) called Korea's national debt "in a very healthy state, only half the global average." According to the IMF's mid- to long-term fiscal outlook, Korea's national debt-to-GDP ratio is expected to remain at 63% by 2030. This is significantly lower than the average for advanced countries and the debt crises major emerging economies have experienced, showing Korea's solid financial fundamentals. In particular, compared with major emerging economies such as China and Brazil, which face pressure to repay debts with a record maturity of more than $9 trillion in 2026 alone, South Korea has secured stable fiscal capacity, giving it an edge in international credibility.

"What matters more than the size of debt is the direction of money" ...Remaining Tasks for the Korean Economy

However, experts say that the government should not simply settle for the low debt ratio. If the government manages its finances too conservatively at a time when competition for technological hegemony is intensifying, it could risk losing its future growth engine. The IMF also pointed out to the South Korean government, saying, "Now is not the time to focus only on the speed or quantity of debt growth," and emphasized, "It is more important than that whether fiscal investment is being invested properly in the direction of strengthening future economic fitness and productivity." Currently, Korea faces major challenges such as the energy transition and building an AI and semiconductor ecosystem to achieve global carbon neutrality, along with a decline in potential growth rates due to severe low birthrates and an aging population. In particular, the economy must quickly transform into a high-efficiency, high-value-added model amid persistent external shocks. After all, smart financial management will be the challenge ahead. Amid a global debt war, Korea must use strong fiscal soundness as a weapon, but it should focus on expanding core high-tech and eco-friendly infrastructure. Now is the time to cut wasteful spending and boldly invest in growth engines.

The Effects of Trade and Exchange Rate Changes on Our Daily Lives – Jeha Lee

Recently, news and newspapers have frequently discussed rising exchange rates and inflation. At first, I thought exchange rates were simply economic terms related to changes in money's value. However, after researching the topic, I realized that exchange rates are closely connected to our daily lives. In particular, South Korea depends heavily on exports and imports, so changes in exchange rates strongly affect it. Therefore, exchange rate fluctuations can affect not only businesses but also consumers.

An exchange rate is the rate at which one country's currency is exchanged for another country's currency; the foreign exchange market sets it through supply and demand for foreign currencies. For example, with the Korean won and the U.S. dollar, when demand for the dollar increases, the dollar's value rises while the won's value falls. Conversely, when the supply of dollars increases, the dollar's value falls and the won's value rises

Exchange rate changes significantly affect the economy. When the won strengthens, export prices expressed in foreign currencies rise, while import prices fall. As a result, exports may decrease, and imports may increase. In addition, foreign tourists may feel that traveling in Korea has become more expensive, which can reduce tourism revenue. These changes can eventually affect the current account balance and economic growth. On the positive side, the burden of repaying foreign currency loans may decrease, improving companies' financial structure.

Exchange rate fluctuations also affect people's daily lives. For example, when the won-dollar exchange rate rises, export companies can earn more profit from overseas sales, which may benefit workers in those industries. However, people traveling abroad or sending money overseas may face a greater financial burden because they need to spend more Korean won than before. As a result, the effects of exchange rate increases or decreases can vary depending on the situation and the people involved.

Most importantly, the speed of exchange rate changes often matters more than whether the rate rises or falls. If exchange rates fluctuate sharply over a short period, uncertainty about import and export prices increases, and trade activity may shrink. Unexpected losses can also negatively affect the national economy. Exchange rates also influence international capital flows. Depending on expected exchange rate movements, foreign investors may change their investments in Korean assets, while Korean investors may also change their investments in overseas assets. These changes can increase financial market volatility.

While writing this article, I learned more specifically about how exchange rate changes affect our daily lives and the economy. Economic news used to feel difficult and unfamiliar to me. Still, I found it interesting that exchange rates directly affect the prices of food and everyday goods. In addition, this topic closely relates to my future career interest in trade, which motivated me to research it further. In the future, I would like to continue studying international trade and economic changes in greater depth.

The Effects of Social Media on Teenagers – Kyeongyeol Lee

Social media has become a big part of teenagers' daily lives. Many students use apps like Instagram, TikTok, and YouTube daily to communicate with friends, watch videos, and share their opinions. Social media has both positive and negative effects on teenagers. First, social media helps teenagers communicate more easily. Students can stay in touch with friends and family anytime, anywhere. It also allows teenagers to learn new information quickly. For example, students can watch educational videos, study foreign languages, and learn about world news through social media platforms. However, social media also has harmful effects. Many teenagers spend too much time online, which can reduce time for studying and sleep. In addition, comparing themselves to others on social media can lower teenagers' self-esteem and increase stress or anxiety. Cyberbullying is another serious problem because hurtful comments and messages can emotionally damage young people.

Despite these problems, social media can be useful if teenagers use it wisely. Setting time limits and using social media for positive purposes can help reduce negative effects. Parents, teachers, and students should work together to create healthy social media habits. In conclusion, social media greatly influences teenagers' lives. It can provide communication, information, and entertainment, but it can also cause stress and addiction. Therefore, teenagers should learn how to use social media in a balanced, responsible way.

The World Inside an Airport – Mina Han

When people think about airports, they usually think of busy schedules, airplanes, and exciting trips. However, airports are more than travel hubs. They are special spaces where people from different countries, cultures, and backgrounds meet every day. In many ways, an airport feels like a small world inside one building. One of the most interesting things about airports is the variety of people you can see. Travelers speak many different languages, wear different styles of clothing, and carry their own cultures with them. Some people may be visiting a country for the first time, while others may be returning home after a long journey. Even while waiting for a flight, people can experience different cultures simply by looking around the airport. Airports also try to make travelers from around the world feel comfortable. Many airports provide multilingual signs, international food, and spaces such as prayer rooms for people of different religions. These services help travelers feel welcomed and respected, even in a foreign country.

As a result, airports have become places where cultural understanding happens naturally. Airport staff also play an important role in connecting cultures. Ground staff members help passengers check in, answer questions, and solve problems when travelers are confused or nervous. Flight attendants communicate with people from many different countries during flights and help passengers feel safe and comfortable. Their jobs are not only about providing service, but also about understanding people from different backgrounds with kindness and respect. Today, the world is more connected than ever. Airports are one of the few places where people from completely different cultures can share the same space for a short time. Even if they speak different languages, they share the same journey. In this way, airports quietly bring people together. Personally, I think airports are meaningful places because they allow people to experience the world in one space. Watching people from different countries interact reminds us that, even with different cultures and languages, we are still connected. That is why I believe airports are much more than places for transportation. They are places where the world meets.

PET bottle decomposition takes 500 years—is it just a delicious meal for this microorganism? – Minjun Choi

It takes a staggering 500 years for a single plastic bottle we commonly use and discard to decompose completely in nature. However, an incredible microorganism can eat and grow on this extremely nonbiodegradable synthetic material: the bacterium *Ideonella sakaiensis*, which shocked the global scientific community when researchers discovered it in 2016. At the time, Japanese researchers were examining soil and wastewater samples near a plastic recycling plant when they isolated this new bacterium, which clings to the surface of plastic films and, for the first time, eats them away. Plastic is an artificial substance humans invented. It has a structure that never existed in the natural world. So, a microorganism evolving the ability to use it as a food source in just a few decades is an immense biological discovery. The secret to how *Ideonella* bacteria digest plastic lies in two special enzymes that act like molecular scissors and are secreted from their bodies. Once the bacterium attaches to the plastic surface and secretes the PETase enzyme, it chops the tough, massive plastic chains into an intermediate substance called MHET.

Next, the secreted MHETase enzyme breaks MHET down into ethylene glycol and terephthalic acid, harmless, eco-friendly basic components. The bacteria absorb these final components and use them as an energy source for life activities; in a warm environment of about 30 degrees Celsius, they can completely decompose plastic bottles without a trace in just a few weeks. Biological decomposition technology using *Ideonella* bacteria is drawing attention because it not only eliminates waste but also restores plastic to its pure, original chemical state. While conventional plastic recycling produces lower-quality materials or harmful substances when melted with heat or burned, this bacterium enables a truly eco-friendly resource-circulation system in which discarded plastic bottles can be repeatedly melted down to create brand-new bottles without extracting new crude oil. In the face of the massive plastic crisis confronting humanity, nature has offered a remarkable answer through the evolution of *Ideonella* bacteria, and research on this tiny microorganism is expected to become a core environmental technology to help save the planet in the future.

The Mysterious Beaked Whale: A Mysterious Creature Swimming Through the Darkness of the Deep Sea – Juha Lim

Have you ever heard of the beaked whale?
The beaked whale family consists of 24 species distributed throughout the world's oceans. Because beaked whales inhabit the deep sea and spend long periods diving to great depths in search of food, we know relatively little about them. However, twenty years of persistent research have greatly expanded our knowledge of these mysterious creatures hidden beneath the deep-sea surface. In this article, I will introduce findings from a study led by researchers at the U.S. Naval Information Warfare Center (NIWC), including researcher Elizabeth Henderson, who observed beaked whales and published the results in the international journal Marine Mammal Science. The study was conducted from May 31 to June 20, 2024, beginning and ending in San Diego, California. The research area extended as far south as 25.87°N, 113.63°W, south of Mexico's Baja California Peninsula. The researchers focused on seamounts and other underwater features with depths and terrain suitable for beaked whales. In June 2024, researchers recorded six beaked whale sightings off Baja California, Mexico. Except for one goosebeaked whale sighting, researchers initially could not identify the other five. However, photographs, genetic analyses, or acoustic analyses confirmed them as ginkgotoothed beaked whales. I will describe in detail the appearance and behavior of the beaked whales observed during the first two encounters. I observed the first beaked whale at 1:14 p.m. on June 1, 2024. An acoustic detector detected a signal, prompting the vessel to reduce speed and conduct a box-shaped search pattern. The signal lasted approximately two minutes. Later, at 4:24 p.m., the vessel detected another signal, which continued for 29 minutes. At 4:42 p.m., while the signal was still being detected, the crew observed a single beaked whale approaching the vessel's starboard side and surfacing three or four times. The crew also observed the whale roll onto its side about 20 meters from the vessel before diving beneath it. Researchers estimated the whale at 4–5 meters long and gray in color. Because it showed no bite marks or other distinctive markings, researchers believed it was a juvenile or subadult. Based on its narrow body and relatively small size, researchers tentatively identified it as a member of the genus Mesoplodon, a genus of toothed whales in the beaked whale family. It was unclear whether the individual was part of the group producing the underwater sounds or was traveling separately. Researchers detected no further signals for some time. Then, at 12:28 p.m. the following day, researchers detected an acoustic signal lasting 2.6 minutes 1.8 kilometers from the first sighting location, although no beaked whales were observed at the surface. The Second observation began at 12:29 p.m. on June 5, 2024. At least three beaked whales were observed approximately 900
meters from the starboard side of the vessel, slowly rolling and swimming near the surface. One adult male had a large, distinctive white patch just below its right dorsal fin. The beaked whales surfaced several times before diving again at 12:30 p.m. They had dark gray bodies with several white patches. They had dark gray bodies with several white patches. The largest individual was approximately 4–5 meters long and was identified as belonging to the genus Mesoplodon based on its flattened head and beak length. At 1:06 p.m., three or four beaked whales were observed about two kilometers away, arching their bodies upward as though foraging. This raised the possibility of two separate groups. Despite diving at steep angles, however, a group resurfaced approximately 1.5–2 kilometers away at around 1:30 p.m. The group appeared to consist of four or five beaked whales, including the adult male with the distinctive white patch. After staying at the surface for several minutes, they arched their bodies again and dove at a steep angle. At 1:42 p.m., the acoustic team detected a signal lasting less than one minute, after which they detected no additional signals. At 2:41 p.m., the team observed a pair of beaked whales near the horizon alongside a longbeaked whale, but believed they belonged to a different group. This study reports the first at-sea observation of genetically confirmed ginkgotoothed beaked whales. We identified their echolocation signals as BW43. These observations provided valuable information about the coloration, physical characteristics, social behavior, and diving patterns of the ginkgotoothed beaked whale. The sightings described above, along with observations of adult, subadult, juvenile, and calf ginkgotoothed beaked whales, revealed changes in coloration patterns across developmental stages. Researchers also confirmed the development of the distinctive white beaktip in adult males, a feature absent in subadult males. Combining these findings with previous records and existing acoustic detection data, the researchers also examined the ginkgotoothed beaked whale's distribution across the North Pacific.

In conclusion, the ginkgotoothed beaked whale appears to inhabit the eastern Pacific more frequently than previously thought and is associated with temperate waters. Collecting additional acoustic data throughout the Pacific and Indian Oceans, including waters around Australia and New Zealand, as well as the South China Sea and East China Sea, could help researchers better determine the species' range. The deep sea is a mysterious realm that humans cannot easily explore directly, and its creatures naturally inspire even greater curiosity because so much about them remains unknown. Through this research on beaked whales, I became even more fascinated by whales, some of the ocean's largest and most remarkable creatures. In recent years, whales have continued to face threats to their survival, including illegal hunting and the distribution of meat from protected whale species. If we can develop greater interest in and appreciation for whales and work together to protect them, perhaps we can help create a world where humans and marine life can continue to coexist peacefully on the same planet.

From Malatang to Buldak: Is Our Obsession with Spicy Food Actually a Craving for Chemical Pain? – Siwoo Song

In recent years, a spicy food craze has swept through Gen Z and young adults. While many use it to relieve stress, the academic community emphasizes that spiciness isn't a taste but a pain sensation. Capsaicin in chili peppers, the main source of spiciness, activates a receptor protein in the mouth called 'TRPV1' rather than the taste cells on the tongue. TRPV1 originally detects dangerous heat above 43°C. When capsaicin molecules bind to this receptor, the brain is tricked into believing that the mouth is actually on fire. The best way to erase this spicy pain depends on the molecule's chemical structure. Drinking water when it is spicy does not help much. Capsaicin is a fat-soluble (nonpolar) compound with a long carbon chain, so it doesn't dissolve in water, a polar molecule; instead, it spreads throughout the mouth. Dairy products like milk or yogurt are effective. This is because milk fat dissolves the nonpolar capsaicin, and casein, a milk protein, binds strongly to capsaicin, forcibly separating the molecules from the receptor.

The reason we become addicted to spiciness is also because of this chemical pain. Believing the body is in danger, the brain releases endorphins and dopamine, natural painkillers, to reduce the pain. In this process, humans experience a strange pleasure and relief from stress. This craze is a good example showing how everyday chemical reactions affect human emotions. However, because excessive capsaicin irritates the gastric mucosa, people should enjoy it safely within a range that the digestive organs can handle.

Do You Think Philosophy Is Hard? – Jian Lee

: Find Your Everyday Philosophy Type and Shatter That Stereotype!

"Ugh, today's lunch menu looks terrible... Should I just hit the vending machine?"
"That guy who's freeriding on our team project—should I just give him a bad peer review?"

If you're a high school student, you probably have thoughts like these several times a day. But did you know? In every one of these minor moments of choice, you are already "doing philosophy." When many students hear the word "philosophy," they often think of thick books, difficult terms, and philosophers on an exam syllabus. As a result, philosophy can seem like a boring, difficult subject, far removed from our own lives. So why does philosophy feel so distant? Perhaps it's because we've only learned philosophy as 'a test subject to memorize for grades.' But in reality, philosophy is nothing grand or complicated. Philosophy is the process of thinking and asking ourselves what we truly value and what principles guide our actions. Even the small choices we make every day contain our own values and standards for life. In the end, philosophy isn't a discipline that exists only in textbooks; it's a living, breathing way of thinking in our daily lives. So, which philosopher's ideas lie behind the choices you usually make? To help you approach the wonderful world of philosophy a little more easily and familiarly, I have prepared a simple test to find the "philosopher who resembles me "through your daily routine in the classroom. From your walk to school to your walk back home, choose honestly!

Q1. On your way to school in the morning, the crosswalk signal starts blinking! There are no cars, but if you don't cross now, you will definitely be late...?
A) "What's the point of running...? Maybe being late is just my fate." I keep walking at my own pace.
B) "Even if I get demerit points, I would never cross on a red light." I stop and wait for the light to turn green.
C) "There are no cars anyway, let's go!" Avoiding demerit points is all that matters, so I dash across the crosswalk as fast as I can.
D) "If I am not late, I'll feel better and my whole day will go smoothly." I run for my own sake.
E) "Isn't this whole school attendance rule oppressive in the first place?" I question the school rules themselves.

Q2. Your class festival booth was a huge success! Your class earned quite a lot of money. How should it be used?
A) "Ugh, long meetings are annoying. Things will work out somehow."
B) "Let's follow the class rules and donate it to the most proper and moral place."
C) "Co "teff" ctiveness is the best! Let's have a huge tteokbokki party so everyone can eat until they are full!"
D) "We "should" d divide it fairly according to how much each person worked during the festival."
E) "Let's do it so even the students who felt left out during the festival because of money can enjoy it equally."

Q3. During a group performance assignment, one team member openly tries to freeload by using their private academy as an excuse. What would you do?
A) "Sigh... I'll do a little more myself." I let it slide because I do not want to fight.
B) "Group projects are a student's responsibility. If you have any conscience, you should take your name off the project." I warn them firmly.
C) "If our group loses points, I'm the one who suffers." I'll assign them to some easy role and carry them to the finish line.
D) "If you did not work, you do not deserve the reward." I could remove their name from the presentation slides.
E) Honestly, society literally bred them to be a college admissions monster, so that'swheree this comes from. They're a victim of the system, if you think about it.

Q4. While watching Instagram Reels, you see an unbelievably rude "subway/group project villain" video. What makes you the angriest?
A) I cannot understand why someone would intentionally create conflict in a peaceful world.
B) They completely threw away the most basic manners and rules that people should follow.
C) They caused inconvenience and suffering to the people around them.
D) They violated other people's freedom and rights.
E) Their selfish behavior and unfair attitude make me angry.

Q5. Which type of student are you during exam season?
A) "It'll all work out somehow~" No all-nighters, plenty of beauty sleep, and keeping anxiety at bay: the 'Mental Care' Type.
B) "My planner is my lifeline." Sticking strictly to a set routine like clockwork. The 'BytheBook' Type.
C) "Efficiency is all about exams!" Digging only into past exams and summary notes with the highest chance of appearing. The 'HighYield' Type.
D) "I've got this under control, leave me alone." Hitting the study cafe solo, where absolutely nobody can bother me. The 'Lone Wolf' Type.
E) "Ask me anything if you're stuck!" Sharing top tips with friends so everyone can level up their grades together. The 'Team Player' Type.

[Results] Which philosopher matches your personality?
See which letter you chose the most!

Mostly A's → 'Laozi(노자)'
#Go_With_The_Flow #ZenMaster
Summary: A true visual of 'Wu Wei' (nonaction 무위자연)— a chill, bighearted soul who stays completely unbothered by academic stress and couldn't care less about fierce competition.

Mostly B's → 'Kant'
#Human_Planner #Live_By_The_Rules
Summary: The icon of honesty who constantly asks, "Would I be proud if my actions were printed in a textbook?" They absolutely can't stand people who cross the line.

Mostly C's → 'Bentham'
#Pro_Pragmatist #King_of_Efficiency
"The greatest happiness for the greatest number!" A sharp thinker who quickly weighs the pros and cons to ensure their choice brings the maximum benefit to everyone.

Mostly D's → 'Adam Smith'
#Free_Spirit #Give_Me_Liberty_Or_Give_Me_Death
Summary: The ultimate boss of autonomy who runs things their own way, like the "invisible hand." They absolutely loathe it when others try to micromanage or judge their style.

Mostly E's → 'Marx'
#For_Justice #A_Better_World_Together
Summary: The passionate type whose blood boils at unfairness or discrimination at school. Rather than succeeding alone, they want everyone to thrive together in equality and fairness.

How do you like your result? As you've noticed, in split-second decisions—like deciding whether to run when you're late for school or how to handle your group project members—your thoughts already align with those of the great minds throughout history. Philosophy isn't something far out of reach. Taking a closer look at the "why" behind the choices you make every day—that's the beginning of your own philosophy.

Shortform content addiction and the 'popcorn brain' phenomenon in adolescents

– Jihye Won

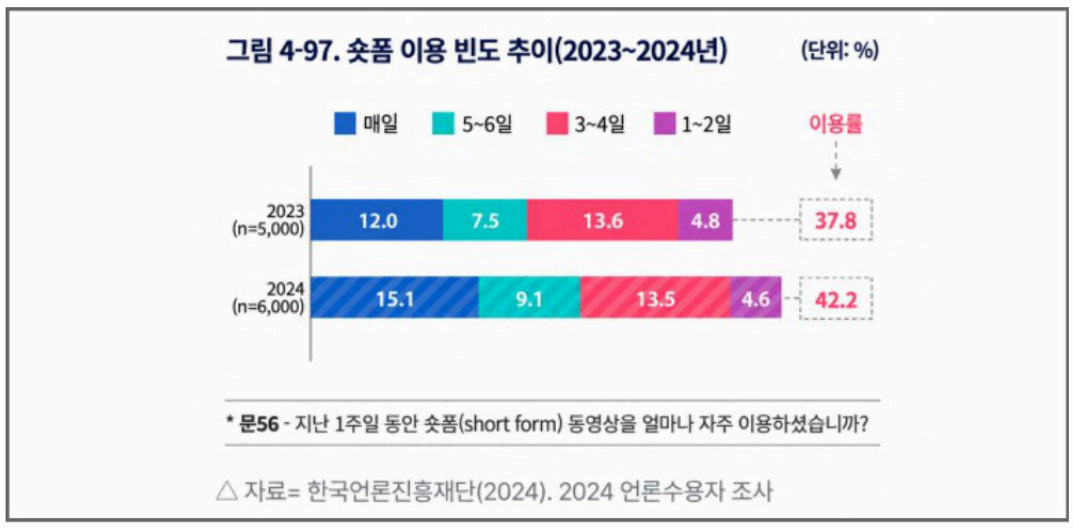
Short-form content, which increasingly dominates teenagers' lives, is gradually changing their brains' structure. This phenomenon is called "Popcorn Brain," a state in which the brain reacts only to intense, immediate stimulation while becoming numb to ordinary, slower forms of stimulation. The human brain releases dopamine, a pleasure-related hormone, whenever it encounters something new. However, short-form content delivers strong stimulation repeatedly in a very short time, leading to excessive dopamine release. In this process, the prefrontal cortex, which controls rational thinking and impulses, may weaken. As a result, the brain gradually seeks stronger stimulation, making it harder for teenagers to concentrate on calm activities like reading or studying.

One of the most common side effects of short-form content among teenagers is the so-called "Short-Form Format Syndrome." This refers to declining literacy skills, especially the ability to understand the flow and context of long texts, as well as a reduced attention span. Teenagers may also easily feel bored and lethargic in everyday life or show anxiety and aggressive reactions when smartphone use is restricted, revealing problems with impulse control.

Short-form content also contains what is often called a "dopamine prison" structure. Teenagers cannot easily escape from short-form platforms not simply because of weak willpower, but largely because of algorithms. First, the "slot machine effect" is an intermittent reward system in which users keep scrolling without knowing what video will appear next, constantly anticipating new stimulation. During this process, dopamine is repeatedly released. In addition, highly personalized recommendation systems analyze users' watch time, likes, and interests to identify what kinds of stimulation attract them most. AI algorithms then continuously provide customized content to keep users engaged. As a result, teenagers often struggle to decide when to stop watching. This problem is even more serious during adolescence because the limbic system, which controls emotions and pleasure, develops faster than the prefrontal cortex, which controls self-control. As a result, short-form algorithms can be especially harmful to teenagers.

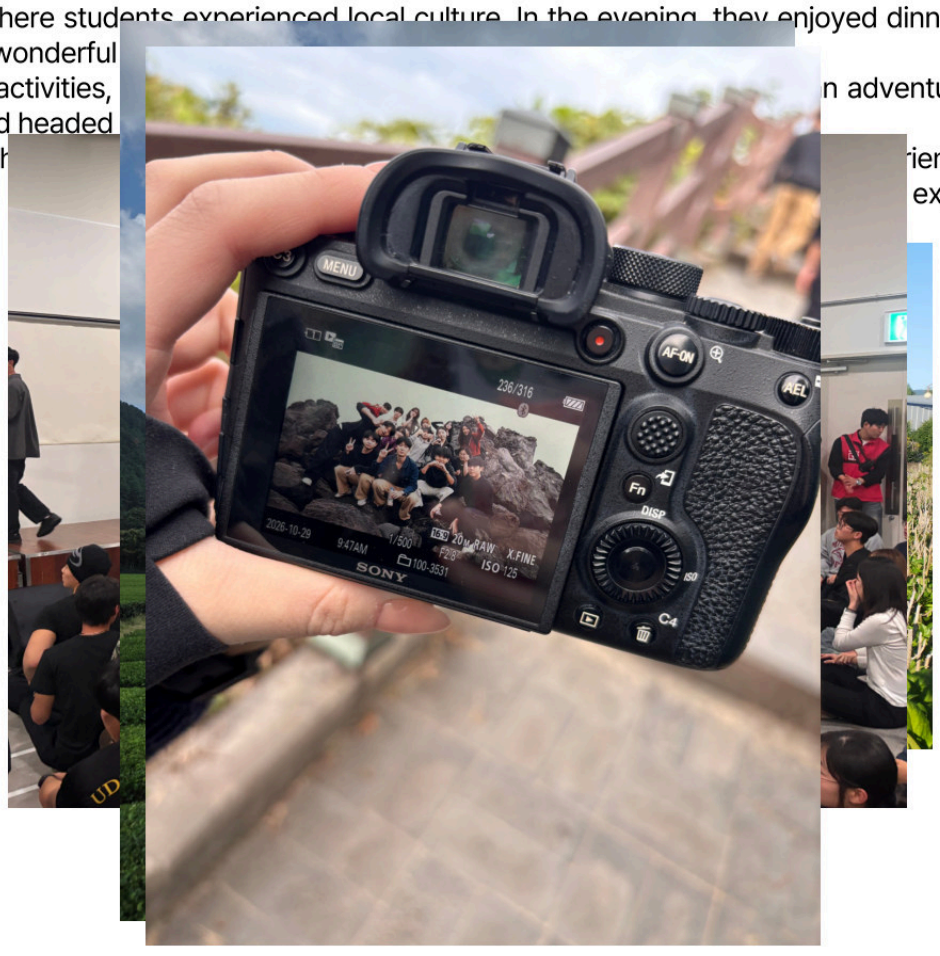
Short-form addiction is not simply an individual problem among teenagers. It can also accelerate the decline in information quality and the crisis in journalism across society. Because short-form videos are too brief to explain the background and context of events fully, they can easily oversimplify or distort complex social issues. In addition, as creators focus on views and likes, sensational or conspiracy-based content keeps rising, making it more likely that teenagers will accept rumors or AI-generated fake videos as true.

To help teenagers overcome short-form addiction, it is important not to rely only on willpower, but also to create physical barriers and environments that reduce smartphone use. In addition, teenagers should replace immediate and intense stimulation with activities that provide “slow dopamine.” For example, reading short essays, poetry collections, or printed newspapers and practicing understanding long passages can help improve concentration and critical thinking skills. Since these activities positively influence the recovery of deep thinking abilities, teenagers should engage in such self-directed activities to overcome short-form addiction.



6 School Excursion

From October 28 to 30, first- and second-year students of Gwangtan High School went on a three-day, two-night school trip to Jeju Island.
On the first day, students enjoyed a light meal at the airport before heading to Jeju. Upon arrival, they took part in tangerine-picking and go-karting activities. The day ended with a delicious barbecue dinner, marking the beginning of an exciting trip.
On the second day, students started their morning with breakfast before visiting the World Automobile & Piano Museum, where they explored a variety of fascinating exhibits. They then enjoyed the beautiful scenery of Handam Beach and Aewol Café Street before visiting Jusangjeolli Cliff. The day’s activities continued with an exciting jet boat ride and a visit to Olle Market, where students experienced local culture. In the evening, they enjoyed dinner at their accommodation, followed by fun recreational activities and a talent show, creating wonderful
On the final day, students enjoyed several more activities, n adventure at Dynamic Maze. After a buffet dinner, they brought their three-day journey to a close and headed
Throughout the trip, students enjoyed Jeju’s breath riends. Beyond the fun and excitement, the trip allowed them to strengthen their friendships and experience and a memorable chapter in their school lives.



[Prism Corner] Off the Clock: Teachers' Private Lives

How do our teachers spend their time outside the classroom? 'Prism Corner' is a special feature in PRISM-TIMES that explores our teachers' hobbies and everyday lives, helping us discover sides of them we may not see in class. Through conversations about what they enjoy and how they started their hobbies, we hope to share the small joys and personal reflections that fill their days.

Joohee Jeon

Q. Could you briefly introduce yourself?
A. I'm Jeon Ju-hee, a geography teacher at Gwangtan High School, and one of my hobbies is listening to the radio.

Q. Is there a particular reason or experience that made you enjoy listening to the radio?
A. I used to listen to the radio every morning on my way to work, and at some point, it simply became a daily habit. Now, I listen to it almost every day without fail. When I'm at home, I also tend to keep the radio on most of the time.

Q. If you were to recommend a radio station or program to students, which one would you choose?
A. One of the biggest appeals of radio is that it feels like I'm communicating with the DJ in real time. Another interesting thing is that radio programs have very different kinds of energy depending on the time of day. Morning programs feel lively and help you start the day with energy, while afternoon programs tend to be calmer and help you wind down. Personally, I prefer programs that give me energy in the morning. Among them, I would recommend ***91.9 Tei's Good Morning FM.***

Q. How do you usually listen to the radio? Do you use a small radio, or do you listen on your phone or through podcasts?
A. I have a radio in my kitchen, so I usually listen to it there. These days, I've noticed that many kitchens have built-in radios, too. During the school semester, I can usually listen to the radio only in the morning, so I mainly tune in to the morning program, ***Tei's Good Morning FM.***
During school vacations, however, I spend more time at home, so I often have the radio on throughout the day. From 7 to 9 a.m., I listen to ***91.9 Tei's Good Morning FM.*** From 9 to 10 a.m., I listen to ***89.1 Lee Hyun-woo's Music Album.*** From 11 a.m. to noon, I listen to ***89.1 Park Myung-soo's Radio Show,*** and from noon to 2 p.m., I listen to ***93.9 Meet Lee Soo-young at Noon***. Since each program is on a different frequency, I have to switch stations according to the schedule. I even make sure to keep track of all those details so that I don't miss the programs I enjoy.

Q. Among those programs, is there a particular segment you would especially recommend to students?
A. I would recommend a segment called ***Brand Land***, which airs every Friday on ***Tei's Good Morning FM***. It introduces the history of different companies, including their success stories and failures, and I find it very interesting. By listening to stories about the growth of familiar companies such as McDonald's and Nike, I think students can learn a lot. If you cannot listen to it when it airs, you can also catch up on the episodes later through podcasts.

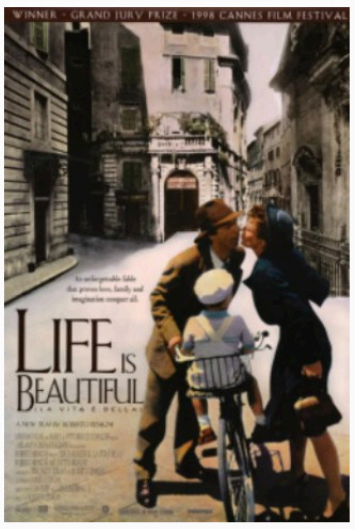
굿모닝FM 테이입니다

Q. Finally, is there anything you would like to say to the students?
A. These days, there probably aren't many students who regularly listen to the radio. However, if you try keeping it on in the background, almost like background music, you may find more to gain from it than you expected. You can also discover and enjoy many different kinds of music. I would definitely recommend giving radio a try. It could be a new and enjoyable experience for you!

Q1. What subjects do you teach, and what are your hobbies?
I teach Korean History and World History. My hobbies include listening to music, keeping a diary, browsing the Nike website, and writing film reviews.

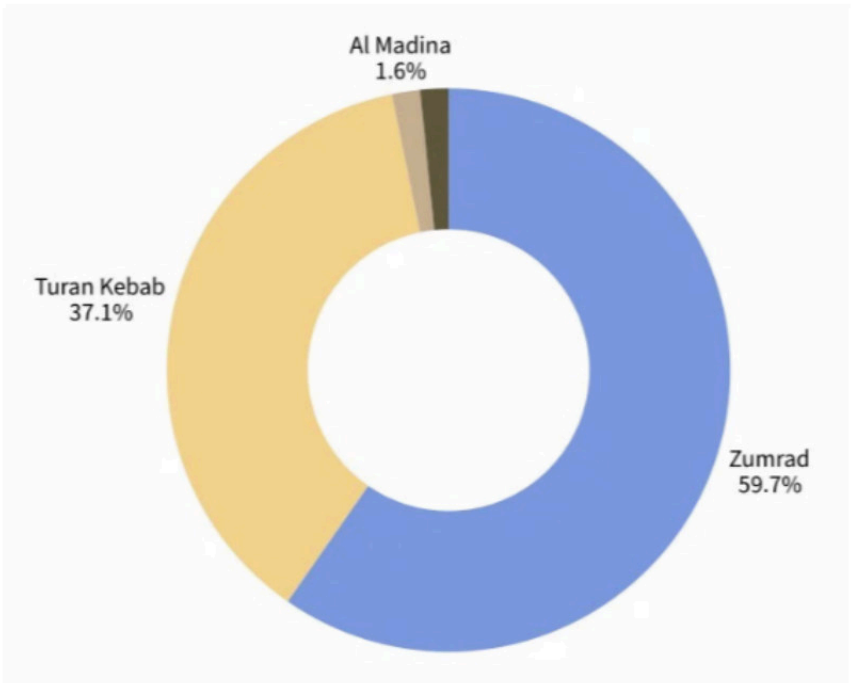
Donggeun Jang

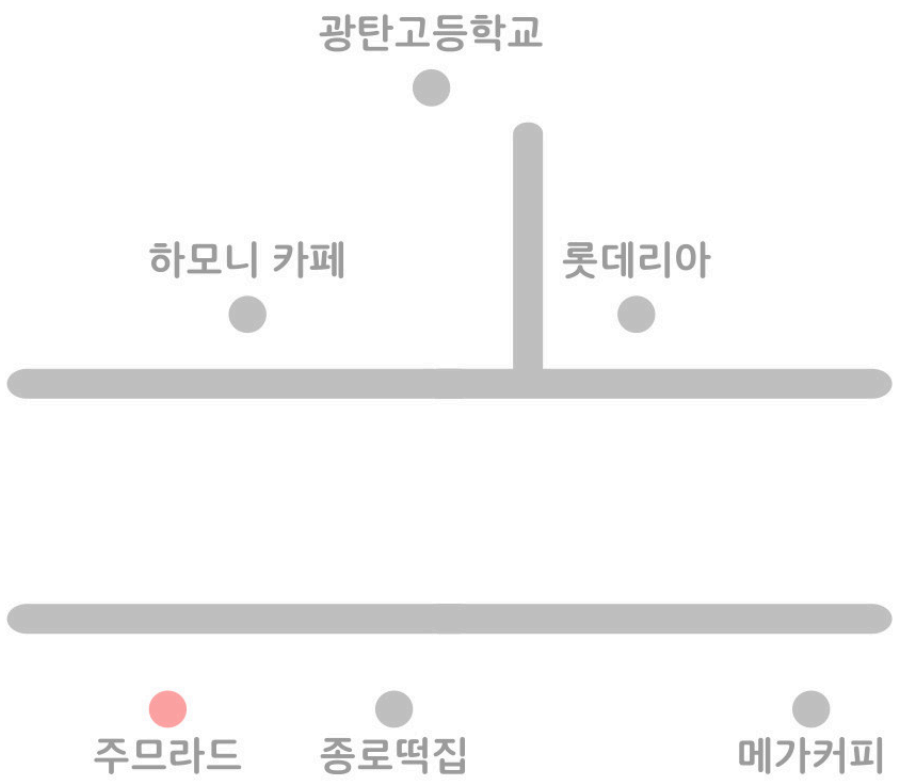
Q2. What inspired you to start writing film reviews?
Ever since I was young, I have enjoyed collecting things and keeping records. Whenever something caught my interest, I wanted to collect everything related to it. I kept a diary, wrote about various things, and clipped interesting magazine articles. Professional baseball was especially popular when I was growing up, and I was a junior member of the MBC Blue Dragons fan club. I collected newspaper articles about the team, put them in a scrapbook, and wrote my own thoughts alongside them. Over time, those experiences naturally developed into a habit of recording my thoughts and experiences.
My memory also played a part in getting me started. Even when I had definitely seen a film, I would find it difficult to remember the details after a while. Sometimes, I would watch a TV program introducing a film I had already seen, and it would feel like something completely new. That made me think it might be a good idea to write down my thoughts and impressions after watching a film. Another source of inspiration came from listening to music. I had always enjoyed it, but at some point, I began to hear the individual instruments within a song. In particular, once I started noticing how the bass was being played, listening to music became much more enjoyable. Appreciating the overall mood or the lyrics is rewarding, but focusing on each instrument allows you to discover things you had never noticed before. I think the same is true of films. Simply following the story can be entertaining, but you discover much more when you look closely at the actors' performances, the camera angles, and the feelings conveyed by the background music. Writing about what I notice and feel satisfies me.



It also allows me to have much richer conversations about films with other people. Through these experiences, I've learned that when you take the time to look closely at something, you can discover unexpected enjoyment in it. That is why I keep writing film reviews and keeping a diary. I have written around 1,650 entries in total, and I've kept a diary for 567 consecutive days. Seeing those records build up gives me a sense of pride and makes me want to keep writing.

Q3. Is there an all-time favorite film you would recommend to students?
There are so many great films, but if I had to choose a personal favorite to recommend, it would be Life Is Beautiful.
It tells the story of a Jewish father and his young son who are sent to a concentration camp during World War II. To keep his son from being frightened by their situation, the father tells him that life in the camp is part of a game. He says that winning the game will earn him a tank, doing everything he can to protect his son's emotional well-being. Although the father ultimately loses his life, the boy encounters an American tank after the war ends and believes that he has won the game and received his prize. To me, this film shows the strength of the human will to bring hope to someone you love, even amid immense pain and sorrow. The contrast between the tragic circumstances and the child's happiness leaves a lasting impression. Our high school students face immense pressure as they prepare for university admissions. Even during difficult times, I hope they can keep their spirits up and hold on to hope. That is why I would recommend this film to them.





"Zumrad," our neighborhood's Uzbek kebab restaurant, proved its status as a local favorite, ranking #1 in a survey with an overwhelming 59.7% of the vote.
Unlike standard kebab spots that leave meat hanging on display all day, Zumrad roasts its chicken in the oven and grills its lamb over charcoal to order, delivering exceptionally juicy, fresh flavors.

The shop is a true hidden gem, built through sheer determination by a young Kumoh National Institute of Technology graduate who launched the business with a modest starting budget of just 7 million KRW. True to its name—which translates to "Emerald"—the restaurant serves every dish with unchanging dedication.
If you are looking for a unique, satisfying bite on your way home, drop by "Zumrad" and experience the smoky, rich taste of authentic flame-grilled kebabs!

An interview with the owner of Zumrad

Q. Could you tell us why the restaurant is named 'Zumrad'?
A. My father originally chose 'Zumrad'. He owns a large furniture company in Uzbekistan with about 70 employees, and the business shares the same name. There's a meaningful story behind it: my late grandmother was named 'Zumrad'. After she passed away, my father started his business and named every enterprise 'Zumrad' to honor her memory. By the way, 'Zumrad' means 'emerald' in Korean.

Q. What makes the kebabs at your restaurant different from those at other foreign restaurants?
A. Typical Turkish kebabs are made by stacking meat on a vertical spit and shaving it off as it cooks, but we grill ours fresh to order to ensure quality. Standard kebabs often sit on the spit for up to eight hours, which inevitably reduces the meat's freshness. Instead of leaving the meat hanging all day, we take a safer, fresher approach: we roast our chicken in the oven and grill our lamb on skewers over charcoal, then slice it individually to make each kebab. Before opening, I consulted Turkish and Uzbek friends who run restaurants in Itaewon. While we could have sourced premade spit meat through them, I decided our current method was the right choice to serve our customers the freshest and safest food possible.

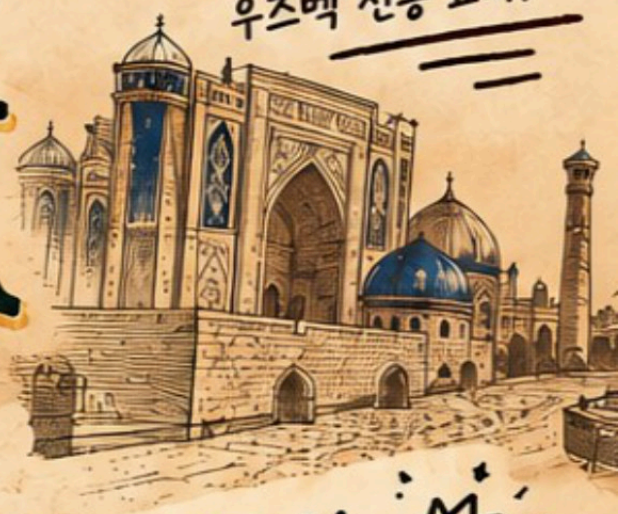
Q. I'm curious about how you came to open a restaurant here in Korea, and what that journey was like.
A. I studied Business Administration for four years at Kumoh National Institute of Technology in Gumi. As a foreigner, I didn't have many job opportunities in Korea, and I preferred starting my own business to working a part-time job for someone else. Since I've always been passionate about cooking, I even uploaded videos of myself making burgers and kebabs on YouTube six years ago.
In my junior year of college, a friend introduced me to this place, but I didn't have any money at the time. So I borrowed 3 million KRW from my father and gathered small amounts from friends to raise 7 million KRW in initial startup capital. Even the 5 million KRW security deposit was beyond my budget, but fortunately, the elderly owner was struggling and wanted to give it up. I persuaded him by asking to take over operations while leaving his deposit in place, and we signed a contract deferring the deposit for one year. With the 7 million KRW I gathered, my friends and I did all the interior work ourselves to save money. For initial ingredients, I approached an Uzbek meat supplier and begged, "We are students starting fresh—could you extend us some credit?" Luckily, he agreed, letting us buy 2 to 4 million KRW worth of meat on credit and finally take our first steps.

멀리 갈 필요 없어요!
우즈베키스탄의 맛을
학교 앞에서!

UZBEK FOOD

정통 우즈벡 요리를 맛볼 수 있는 곳!

항신틈의 흥미가 가득한
우즈벡 전통 요리!



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학생들도 쉽게! ☆
언제든지 편하게!

양꼬치
(우즈벡 전통요리)!!

다양한 음료!!

맛있는 한끼!

다양한 메뉴로
취향대로 즐기는 우즈벡의 맛!

EVENT